Testimony Time

Building & Sharing Your Story of God's Faithfulness

Purpose

To debrief the outreach/mission experience from Week 7, help disciples develop powerful testimonies that glorify God, and train them to recognize God's activity in everyday life—especially through the recent outreach. This week combines REFLECTION (on the mission) and BUILDING (testimonies for the future).

Why This Matters

After going out on mission in Week 7, disciples need space to process what God did. Many will have fresh testimonies from the outreach experience. Additionally, by Week 8, disciples have seven weeks of DNA tools, spiritual growth, and "God moments" to draw from. A well-told testimony can change someone's life—it builds faith (Romans 10:17), overcomes darkness (Revelation 12:11), and gives God glory. This week, we teach disciples HOW to craft and share testimonies that connect with others and point them to Jesus.

Preparation (Before the Meeting)

Leaders:

- **CRITICAL:** One week before this meeting (during Week 4), send all disciples the **Testimony Development Worksheet** (see resource below)
- Prepare 2 of your own testimonies using the worksheet framework:
  - **Testimony 1:** Your salvation story OR a major life transformation
  - **Testimony 2:** A recent answer to prayer or "God moment" from the last month
- Be ready to explain WHY your testimonies are effective (what makes them compelling?)
- Review the "STORY Framework" teaching (see below)

Disciples:

- Complete the **Testimony Development Worksheet** before the meeting
- Bring at least 1 testimony using the worksheet structure

Meeting Structure (90 minutes)

1. Opening Worship (5 minutes)

- Sing 1-2 songs of thanksgiving and celebration
- Worship prepares hearts to see and share God's goodness

2. Outreach Debrief (15 minutes)

Facilitate a debrief of the Week 7 outreach/mission experience:

Ask the group:

- "What did you experience during the outreach? What stood out to you?"
- "Where did you see God show up? Any specific moments?"
- "What challenged you? What encouraged you?"
- "Did anyone have a conversation, encounter, or moment that felt significant?"
- "How did this experience grow your faith?"

Leader's Role:

- Celebrate every story—big or small
- Help disciples see God's activity in moments they might overlook
- Ask follow-up questions: "What did that teach you about God?"
- Transition: "Many of you just shared fresh testimonies from the outreach. That's exactly what we're going to work on tonight—how to capture and share these stories powerfully."

Why This Matters:

This debrief serves as a natural bridge into testimony building. Disciples are processing real experiences of God's activity, which makes the testimony workshop more concrete and immediate.

3. Leader Testimony Modeling (10 minutes)

Leader 1 shares first testimony (Salvation/Transformation story):

- Share your prepared testimony naturally and compellingly
- After sharing, PAUSE and debrief:

Ask the group:

- "What made that testimony easy to follow?"
- "What details stood out to you?"
- "What did you learn about God's character from that story?"

Leader points out key elements:

- "Notice how I shared WHERE I was before (my struggle/need)"
- "I told you WHAT God did (specific action/encounter)"
- "I explained HOW my life changed as a result (transformation)"
- "This is called the STORY Framework—we'll teach you this tonight"

Leader 2 shares second testimony (Recent "God moment"):

- Share your recent answer to prayer or everyday God encounter
- Again, debrief what made it effective:
    - Specific details (not vague)
    - God as the hero (not me)
    - Honest about the struggle
    - Clear outcome

Transition:

"You all have stories like these. Tonight, we're going to help you BUILD powerful testimonies using the same framework we just modeled. Pull out your Testimony Development Worksheets—we're going to work through them together."

4. Teaching: The STORY Framework (15 minutes)

What is a testimony? A testimony is your personal account of God's activity in your life. It's not just about salvation—it's about every moment God shows up, provides, heals, speaks, guides, or transforms.

- **They build faith** (Romans 10:17 - "Faith comes by hearing")
- **They overcome darkness** (Revelation 12:11 - "We overcome by the blood of the Lamb and the word of our testimony")
- **They give God glory** (He gets credit, not us)
- **They connect with non-believers** (stories are universal; people relate to struggle and hope)

The STORY Framework (write this on a board or share on screen):

S - STRUGGLE (Before)

- Where were you before God intervened?
- What was the problem, need, or pain?
- What did life look like without God's intervention?

T - TURNING POINT (The Moment)

- When/how did God show up?
- What specific event, encounter, or realization happened?
- How did you recognize it was God?

O - OUTCOME (After)

- What changed as a result?
- How is your life different now?
- What freedom, healing, or breakthrough did you experience?

R - REFLECTION (What You Learned)

- What did this experience teach you about God?
- What did it teach you about yourself?
- How did it grow your faith?

Y - YOUR INVITATION (The Call)

- What do you want others to take away from your story?
- What hope can you offer them?
- How can they experience God's faithfulness too?

Examples of testimony types:

- **Salvation stories** - How you came to faith in Jesus
- **Healing testimonies** - Physical, emotional, or spiritual healing
- **Provision testimonies** - God meeting financial, relational, or practical needs
- **Breakthrough testimonies** - Freedom from strongholds, addictions, lies
- **Everyday faithfulness** - Answered prayers, "God moments," divine appointments

What makes a testimony POWERFUL:

✅ **Specific** - "God provided $500 for rent" (not "God is just so good")

✅ **Concise** - 3-5 minutes max (not 20 minutes)

✅ **God-centered** - He's the hero, not you

✅ **Honest** - Include the struggle, not just the victory

✅ **Relatable** - Others can see themselves in your story

✅ **Hope-filled** - Points people to Jesus as the answer

What to avoid:

❌ Vague generalities - "God is good" without specifics

❌ Making yourself the hero - "I finally figured it out"

❌ Over-spiritualizing - Using Christianese non-believers won't understand

❌ Rambling without structure - No clear beginning, middle, end

❌ Leaving out the struggle - Only sharing the victory makes it unrelatable

5. Testimony Workshop: Building Your Story (35 minutes)

Instructions: "Now it's your turn. You received the Testimony Development Worksheet last week. Let's refine your testimonies together using the STORY Framework."

Step 1: Pair Up (5 minutes)

- Break into pairs (leader with disciple, or disciple with disciple)
- Each person shares which testimony they want to focus on tonight

Step 2: Workshop in Pairs (20 minutes - 10 min each person)

- Person 1 shares their testimony draft out loud using their worksheet
- Person 2 listens and gives feedback:
    - "What part was most compelling?"
    - "Where could you add more specific details?"
    - "Is the STORY Framework clear?
    - "Is God the hero of this story?"
- Person 1 makes notes on their worksheet
- Switch roles and repeat

Leaders circulate during this time:

- Ask clarifying questions
- Help disciples identify what's working and what needs refinement
- Encourage them: "This is powerful—don't be afraid to share the messy parts"

Step 3: Volunteer Shares (10 minutes)

- Ask them to share their refined testimony with the whole group
- After each testimony, the group gives feedback:
    - "What did you hear about God's character?"
    - "What made this testimony compelling?"
    - "How does this encourage your faith?"

Affirm every testimony: "This is what we're learning to do—see God's activity in our lives and tell others about it. You're becoming witnesses."

6. Challenge & Commission (10 minutes)

This Week's Challenge:

1. **Refine your testimony** - Use the feedback you received tonight and polish your story
2. **Practice out loud** - Share your testimony with someone outside this group (friend, family, coworker, stranger)
3. **Add to your worksheet** - Write down any new "God moments" that happen this week
4. **Pray for opportunities** - Ask God to open doors for you to share your testimony

Next Week Preview:

"Next week, we'll dive into Breaking Strongholds—identifying and overcoming lies that hold us back. Here's the thing—your testimonies tonight may have revealed some strongholds without you realizing it. Pay attention this week to any patterns or struggles that keep coming up. Keep building your library of testimonies."

7. Closing Prayer & Declaration (5 minutes)

Leader prays:

"Father, thank You for Your faithfulness in each of our lives. Thank You that every person in this room has a story to tell—a story of Your goodness, Your power, Your presence. Give us boldness to share our testimonies this week. Let our stories build faith in others and give You all the glory. In Jesus' name, Amen."

Declare together:

"God is faithful. He is good. He is with us. And we will testify."

Coaching Tips for Leaders

Common Struggles:

"I don't have any big testimonies." → "You don't need a dramatic story to have a powerful testimony. Even 'small' testimonies reveal God's character. Did He answer a prayer? Provide for a need? Give you peace in chaos? That's a testimony."

"I'm not a good storyteller." → "That's why we gave you the STORY Framework. Just follow the structure: Struggle, Turning Point, Outcome, Reflection, Your Invitation. It's like a roadmap—just fill in the details."

"I don't want to sound preachy or religious." → "Great instinct. The best testimonies are conversational and relatable. Tell your story like you're talking to a friend over coffee. Use normal language, not Christianese."

"What if someone didn't complete their worksheet?" → "That's okay. Use the workshop time to help them build their testimony from scratch. Ask guiding questions: 'When has God shown up in your life? What changed as a result?'"

"Nothing happened this week—I don't have a new testimony." → Dig deeper. Ask:

- "Did you pray about anything this week?"
- "Did God speak to you through Scripture or another person?"
- "Did He protect you from something you didn't even realize?"

Someone's testimony is vague or generic ("God is just so good"): → Ask follow-up questions:

- "Can you give me a specific example of when you experienced His goodness?"
- "What happened that made you say that?"
- "When did this happen? What did it look like?"

Someone rambles and talks for 15+ minutes:

- "I love this story. Let's pause here so everyone gets a chance to share. Can you give us the main point in one sentence?"

Someone's "testimony" is actually complaining:

- "I hear that was hard. Where did you see God in that situation?"
- "What did you learn about Him through that?"

What to Watch For

Good Signs:

- People are recognizing God in everyday life
- Faith is increasing as they hear each other's stories
- They're learning to tell their story clearly and compellingly
- Gratitude is growing

Red Flags:

- Someone can't identify any testimony (possible spiritual dryness)
- Testimonies are all about them, not God
- No recent testimonies (they're not walking with God currently)

Leader Debrief (After the Meeting)

- Who had powerful testimonies?
- Who struggled to identify God's activity?
- What patterns did we notice?
- How can we help them see God more clearly?

Follow-Up:

- Text individual disciples mid-week: "Have you had a chance to share your testimony with anyone yet?"
- Celebrate when someone shares their testimony—ask them how it went
- Post in group chat: "Drop a 🙌 if you shared your testimony this week"
- Continue adding your own answered prayers and "God moments" to model testimony-building